every ball, any delivery, for six. If you know you can do it, when do you choose to do it?

That highlights one of batting's most intriguing factors, its individualism. I've never had Alex's problem of succumbing to temptation, because I don't have his extraordinary power. I have three or four reliable elements of influence: if I can't cut, chip or pull the ball, I leave it, or defend.

Someone like Ravi Bopara, who has shared my journey from Maldon to the MCG, has, perversely, had it harder than me because his technique and dexterity allow him more potentially profitable areas on which to concentrate. Those extra options mean he has to make a lot more decisions under pressure than I do.

Handling that distraction, the dilemma of trying to balance pop with prudence, must be a hard thing to deal with. I've noticed that the modern-day generation of fifty-over batsmen tend to kill you one day and go quietly the next. Of them all, Joe Root, a player grounded in old-school techniques, probably emerges as the most consistent.

Cricket isn't losing anything. It is still in a transitional phase, where there is an absolute need to have someone of Rooty's sureness. He is not a natural power hitter, but he is England's pivotal batsman. Add that to the inventiveness of shots that look improvised but are meticulously rehearsed, and you have a proper team.

The Dil Scoop, introduced by Tillakaratne Dilshan at the 2009 World Cup, was a game changer. It was a product of street cricket, played with a tennis ball, in Sri Lanka, where there was little room either side of the wicket. He went down on one knee, leaned into the ball, and swept it over the wicketkeeper's head. Jos Buttler tried it, felt he couldn't do it the Dilshan way, but found his own method, after hour upon hour of painstaking practice. He is of the generation that grew up with T20, which started in 2003. It had an obvious influence, just as I was inspired by Test and four-day county cricket. The modern player must be far more adaptable; the old-school player approached one-day cricket identically to the longer form, apart from self-consciously having a whack in the last fifteen overs.

To be the complete cricketer is very hard, because that demands a very broad skillset. Joe Root, Steve Smith and David Warner are among the very few players who can relate to all forms of the game. Some excel in two,